

■ By Sharda Ugra

One motorsport mogul has banknotes cast in bronze, faced heat over a £10 million (Rs 800 crore) donation to the British Labour Party and was quoted as saying, "I hate democracy. It stops you getting things done."

The other pit boss was accused in the British Parliament of defying United Nations sanctions and supplying fuel to Angola's UNITA rebels, charges he denied saying that the accused was another businessman with the same name.

Bernie Ecclestone, CEO of Formula One Management and owner of the

bronzed banknotes, would upend the contents of an entire Formula 1 garage if it were even suggested that he had anything in common with Tony Teixeira, chairman of A1GP.

F1 and A1 are distant cousins. In motorsport's family tree, F1 is the aristocrat, getting all the fawning attention, finance and glamour. A1, only three seasons old, is an arriviste that has grated on the nerves of the motorsport establishment. But at this moment in time the two codes share one ambition: to manoeuvre their way into the minds and wallets of the biggest audience their sport can reach in the next decade—India.

For F1, India is an untapped oil field.

For A1, it is an empty stage, where putting up the first show could pull in a huge following that could become loyal.

Late last year Ecclestone signed a deal with infrastructure major Jaypee Group and an Indian F1 Grand Prix race is planned for 2010. When the 2008 F1 season opened at Albert Park in Melbourne, the name India echoed over the growling of the waiting engines as Vijay Mallya's Force India F1 team began its campaign alongside Ferrari, McLaren and Williams.

A1 is putting its foot on the floor too. In mid-April, A1GP Asia-Pacific region CEO David Clare will visit proposed sites for an Indian A1GP race targeted late

THE RACE

AS THE 2008 FORMULA 1 SEASON SEES VIJAY MALLYA'S FORCE INDIA TEAM LINED UP ON THE GRID

